

Seed Saving and Heirloom Preservation

Keeping varieties — and the stories attached to them — alive

Why Save Seed

Seed saving is both practical and cultural. It preserves varieties adapted to your own soil and climate, saves money, and keeps heirloom and family varieties from disappearing. For many Southern and Black farming families, a saved bean or pea is a direct link to ancestors who grew it before them.

Open-Pollinated vs. Hybrid

Save seed only from **open-pollinated** (including heirloom) plants — their seed grows true to type. Seed saved from **hybrid** (F1) plants will not reliably reproduce the parent and is not worth saving for trueness.

Easy Crops to Start With

Crop	Method	Notes
Beans / peas	Dry on plant, shell	Self-pollinating, very easy
Tomatoes	Ferment, rinse, dry	Self-pollinating
Okra	Let pods dry, split	Easy
Peppers	Scrape, dry seed	Easy; isolate hot/sweet
Lettuce	Collect dried seed heads	Easy

Storing & Labeling

- Dry seed thoroughly before storage to prevent mold.
- Store in labeled, airtight containers in a cool, dark, dry place.
- Label every variety with name, source, and year — records are the heart of preservation.
- A backyard trial plot becomes a seed library when you keep good notes season to season.